CITY OF SAN MATEO

Agenda Report

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TO: City Council
FROM: Alex Khojikian, City Manager
PREPARED BY: Police Department
MEETING DATE: [INSERT MEETING DATE]

SUBJECT

Authorize the City Manager to Execute an Amendment to the Police Department's Axon Agreement to Include Axon Outpost Fixed Automated License Plate Reader Cameras for an 18-Month Trial

RECOMMENDATION

Staff recommends Council authorize the City Manager or designee to execute Amendment No. [INSERT AMENDMENT NUMBER] to the Police Department's Axon Master Services and Purchasing Agreement to include Axon Outpost fixed Automated License Plate Reader (ALPR) cameras for an initial 18-month trial; authorize the Chief of Police to implement the phased deployment in substantially the form presented; and require staff to return to the City Council with the results of the evaluation before the City incurs a long-term payment obligation or selects a permanent fixed ALPR solution.

BACKGROUND

The San Mateo Police Department (SMPD) has utilized Axon technology for many years, including body-worn cameras, Fleet 3 in-car video and mobile ALPR, Axon Evidence, and Axon Fusus. These systems are used by officers in the field and by personnel assigned to the Real Time Intelligence Center. Axon recently released fixed-camera ALPR technology that operates within the same software environment and is designed to improve efficiency by bringing alerts, live information, investigative searches, digital evidence, permissions, retention, and auditing into a common platform.

SMPD evaluated fixed ALPR products from Axon Enterprise, Inc., Flock Safety, and Motorola Solutions. Motorola presented the lowest normalized core-camera cost, and Flock offered a mature and rapidly deployable fixed-camera network. Axon received the strongest overall assessment because it integrates with the Department's current technology, reduces the need for separate accounts and evidence exports, and provides a unified operational and governance workflow. An 18-month trial will allow SMPD to validate that assessment under actual San Mateo conditions before recommending a long-term solution.

The Police Department complies with California Civil Code Sections 1798.90.5 et seq. regarding ALPR technology. Public agencies must maintain appropriate usage and privacy policies and provide an opportunity for public comment at a regularly scheduled public meeting before implementing an ALPR program. The proposed trial will operate under SMPD policy, applicable state law, and the Department's existing authorization and audit requirements.

DISCUSSION

ALPR is an investigative and public-safety tool that captures license plate and vehicle information from vehicles traveling on public roadways. The technology can assist with stolen vehicles, wanted or missing persons, serious crimes, organized retail theft, and other authorized investigations. An ALPR alert is an investigative lead only. Officers are required to visually confirm the plate and verify the information through an independent law-enforcement source before taking enforcement action.

Axon Outpost is a compact, solar-capable fixed ALPR camera designed for public-safety use. The system provides real-time plate alerts and searchable vehicle information through Axon Vehicle Intelligence. Outpost integrates with Axon Fusus and Axon Evidence, allowing authorized personnel to use the same environment as the Department's existing Fleet 3 mobile ALPR, body-worn camera, in-car video, and digital evidence systems. This integration is expected to improve workflow efficiency, reduce separate accounts and evidence transfers, and support consistent access, retention, and audit controls.

The updated Axon quote is limited to Outpost ALPR cameras and does not include Lightpost PTZ cameras. The pricing schedule includes 54 paid Outpost Technology Assurance Plan (TAP) plans, five additional Outpost plans and subsequent extension plans at no net charge, 59 ALPR software licenses and installation packages, and a delivery schedule listing 60 Outpost cameras. The proposal also includes solar panels, battery and charger enclosures, poles, installation, maintenance,

extended warranties, training, technical support, and scheduled hardware refreshes. The final amendment will confirm the exact number of deployed cameras and any spare equipment, installation locations, implementation schedule, and equipment disposition requirements.

Axon has proposed competitive pricing and a phased approach that places the first scheduled payment after the proposed evaluation period. During the initial 18 months, SMPD will evaluate reliability, plate-read performance, day and night operation, alert latency, cellular and solar performance, maintenance response, investigative value, administrative workload, and integration with Fusus and Evidence. Staff will also review user compliance, audit results, data retention, sharing controls, community feedback, and the ability to produce meaningful public reports.

The trial will give SMPD the opportunity to compare Axon's performance and total operational value with the Flock and Motorola products previously evaluated. At the conclusion of the 18-month period, staff will return to the City Council with the results and a recommendation to continue with Axon, select another vendor, modify the deployment, or discontinue the fixed ALPR program. This approach allows the Department and the community to evaluate the technology before the City makes a long-term commitment.

All security and policy requirements governing the Department's current ALPR program will apply to the trial. Access will be limited to authorized users for legitimate law-enforcement purposes; searches and system activity will be logged and audited; non-evidentiary information will be deleted in accordance with SMPD retention policy; and any sharing will be restricted by Department policy and California law. The trial does not expand the authorized uses of ALPR information.

BUDGET IMPACT

The updated Axon quote identifies a 99-month program beginning October 15, 2026 and ending January 14, 2035, with a net contract cost of $1,137,974.48 and estimated tax of $31,566.52, for a total contract value of $1,169,541.00. The quote reflects a list price of $2,220,466.71 and total savings of $1,082,492.23, or 48.75 percent. The payment schedule begins June 1, 2028, with annual payments increasing from $148,075.15 in 2028 to $187,362.26 in 2034, including estimated tax. No payment is scheduled during the initial evaluation period.

The quote was issued July 20, 2026 and is valid through September 29, 2026. If Council consideration or execution occurs after that date, staff will obtain an updated quote and final agreement language acceptable to the City Attorney. The amendment must preserve the City's ability to discontinue the program at the conclusion of the trial without incurring the remaining long-term charges. If the trial is successful and the City Council authorizes continuation, future payments will be included in the Police Department's operating budget through the annual budget process. Any increase above the quoted amount or any long-term obligation not authorized by this action will be returned to the City Council for approval.

ENVIRONMENTAL DETERMINATION

This action is categorically exempt from the California Environmental Quality Act under CEQA Guidelines Sections 15301 and 15303 because it consists of minor alterations to existing public facilities and the installation of small public-safety equipment. The final environmental determination will be confirmed based on the approved installation locations.

NOTICE PROVIDED

All meeting noticing requirements were met.

ATTACHMENTS

Att 1 - Proposed Amendment No. [INSERT AMENDMENT NUMBER]
Att 2 - Axon Quote Q-865809-003
Att 3 - Fixed ALPR Vendor Comparison
Att 4 - San Mateo Police Department ALPR Policy

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